

SESSION 03

Synthesis & Problem Definition

Turning raw research into a problem worth solving.

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OO WHERE WE LEFT OFF

Session 2

Recap

What you brought into today.

LAST SESSION • CUSTOMER UNDERSTANDING

You learned to **listen** without interpreting.

You surfaced assumptions, wrote discussion guides, ran interviews, and logged raw notes — without editorialising.



What you did before today

01 **Run user interviews**
Real conversations with users on your live project — open questions, listening more than talking.

02 **Log raw notes within 24 hours**
Capture quotes, behaviours, and surprises in your Research Log while memory is fresh.

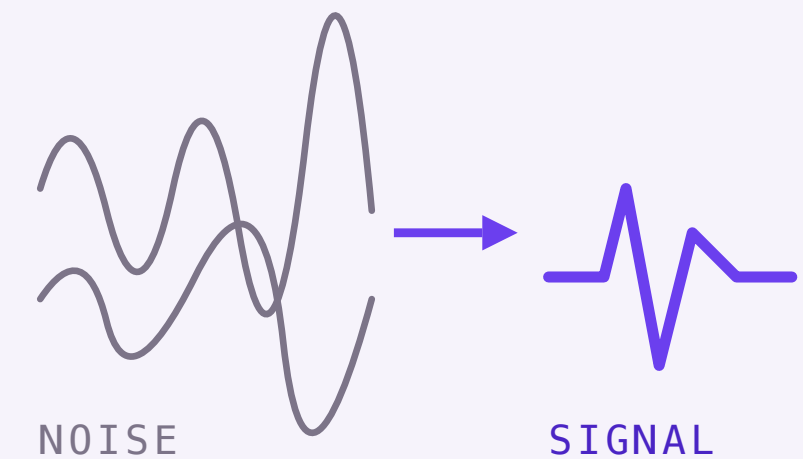
03 **Map Jobs-to-Be-Done**
Start surfacing the jobs your users are trying to get done from what you actually heard.

04 **Begin your Design Decision Log**
A running record of the choices you make and the evidence behind each one.

TODAY'S SHIFT

Now we make
the data **mean**
something.

Research without synthesis is just noise.

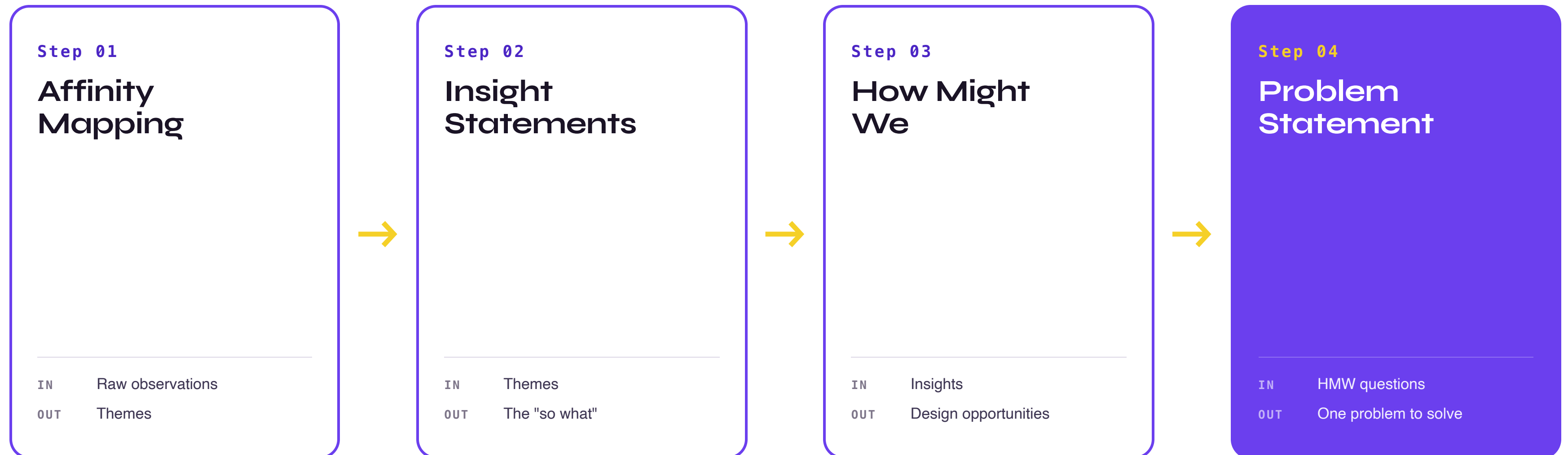


01 HOW IT BUILDS

The Pipeline

Four moves from raw data to a problem worth solving.

Raw notes don't become direction on their own.



Before vs after synthesis

BEFORE

- ✗ "I have interview notes... let me start designing."
- ✗ Jumping to solutions with unprocessed data.
- ✗ Designing based on what felt memorable in the room.



AFTER

- ✓ "I have interview notes. Now I'll find the patterns, name the insights, define the real problem."
- ✓ Letting the data lead before picking a direction.
- ✓ Designing based on what the evidence actually says.

Solo synthesis **vs** workshop synthesis

SOLO

- ✗ You carry all the context.
- ✗ Stakeholders receive a report.
- ✗ Buy-in happens later — if at all.
- ✗ One perspective on the data.

WORKSHOP

- ✓ Context is distributed across the room.
- ✓ Stakeholders co-own the findings.
- ✓ Alignment is a byproduct of the process.
- ✓ Multiple lenses catch what one person misses.

02 BEFORE YOU RUN IT

Setting Up Your Workshop

Before you run the pipeline, get the right people in the room.

Four people who make synthesis **smarter**

01 **Product Manager**
Aligns the roadmap to what users actually said.

02 **Engineer**
Spots technical constraints before they become design assumptions.

03 **Fellow designer**
A second set of eyes on what's a pattern vs. an outlier.

04 **Stakeholder or lead**
Makes prioritisation calls — better if they built the meaning themselves.

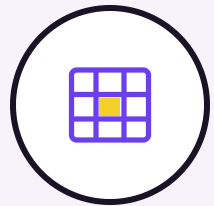
— BEFORE THE SESSION

Three things that make **the room work**



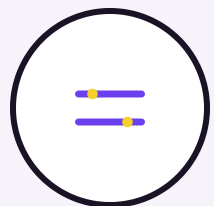
Share raw notes in advance

Give participants 15 minutes to read before the session — not during.



One tool, one board

FigJam or Miro — all raw observations on stickies before anyone arrives.

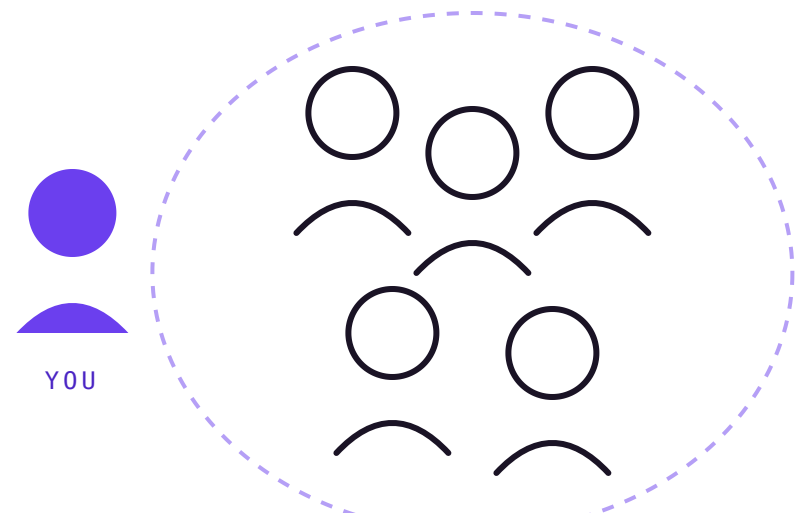


No titles in the room

Everyone clusters as equals. Seniority distorts patterns.

— YOUR ROLE

You hold the **process**, not the answers.



- 01 *Open with the research question.* "We're here to find out what the data tells us — not confirm what we already think."
- 02 *Protect silent clustering time.* Resist the urge to explain notes.
- 03 *Name disagreements as useful.* "That tension is data too."
- 04 *Time-box each step ruthlessly.*
- 05 *Close with: "What surprised you most?"* Surprises are where the real insights live.

03 STEP ONE

Step 1 Affinity Mapping

Your first move — raw notes go in, themes come out.

Affinity mapping, defined

What.

A synthesis method that turns scattered observations into themes — by clustering notes that belong together.

Originated from the Japanese KJ method (Kawakita Jiro, 1960s). Now the most common synthesis move in UX research.

Why.

Patterns don't live in any single note — they live in the spaces between them.

- Surfaces patterns invisible in raw notes
- Forces engagement with every observation, not just the loud ones
- Builds shared understanding in the room
- Makes themes visible, namable, and debatable

When.

After listening — before deciding what it means.

- After interviews, before writing insights
- When you have 30+ observations to make sense of
- When stakeholders disagree on what the research said
- At the start of any synthesis workshop

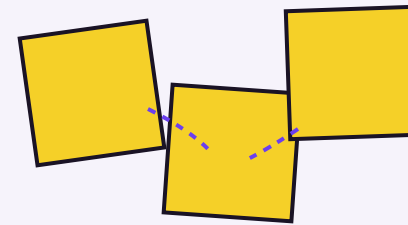
One method, **three moves**



01

One note, one observation

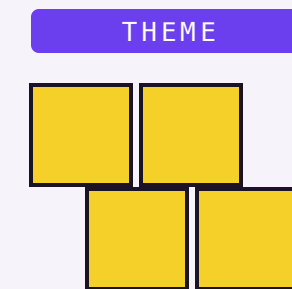
Each quote, behaviour, or data point lives on its own sticky. No grouping yet.



02

Move notes that feel related

Group silently first — don't discuss, just feel. Let the clusters find themselves.



03

Name the cluster

Write a header that captures what unites that group. That header is your theme.

— STEP BY STEP

How to **run it**



ACTIVITY 01 · 10 MIN

6 + 4 Minutes

Recipe app observations are pre-loaded on the shared FigJam board.

Round 1 · 6 min — cluster silently. **Round 2 · 4 min** — label each cluster. Which cluster surprised you? Did any note belong in two places?

04 STEP TWO

Step 2 Insight Statements

You have themes — now name what each one means.

THE DEFINITION



An observation is what you saw or heard. An implication is why it matters for design. Together they make an insight.

Weak insight **vs** strong insight

WEAK

- ✗ "Users find the app confusing."
- ✗ "Users want a simpler interface."
- ✗ "Users liked the new feature."

STRONG

- ✓ "Users can't locate booking status after submission, causing them to call support — a gap in post-action feedback design."
- ✓ "Hospitality managers visit the app 3–5× per shift but navigate 4 screens each time — suggesting a need for a persistent dashboard view."
- ✓ "3 of 4 users completed the flow faster, but all 4 got stuck at the date picker — a specific interaction failure, not a layout issue."

ACTIVITY 02 · 10 MIN

10 Minutes

Pick one moment from your interviews. Write the insight: what did you observe, and what does it mean for the design?

05 STEP THREE

Step 3 How Might We

Turn insights into questions the team can design toward.

— BREAKING IT DOWN

Three words, **one big idea**

How

Assumes it's solvable

Not "can we" or "should we" — it's already a given that it can be done.

Might

Leaves the solution open

Invites exploration. No single right answer yet.

We

It's a team challenge

Builds shared ownership, not one person's burden to solve alone.

— IN PRACTICE

From insight to opportunity

INSIGHT "Users abandon after checkout even when the transaction succeeds — because there is no clear confirmation — breaking trust at the most critical moment in the flow."



HMW →

How might we make it immediately clear that a transaction was successful, without requiring the user to check?

HMW →

How might we reduce user anxiety at the moment between action and confirmation?

HMW →

How might we design a post-payment experience that builds trust instead of doubt?

ACTIVITY 03 · 8 MIN

8 Minutes

Take the insight you wrote. Turn it into 3 different "How Might We" questions.

06 STEP FOUR

Step 4 Problem Statement

Converge — one problem the whole team can act on.

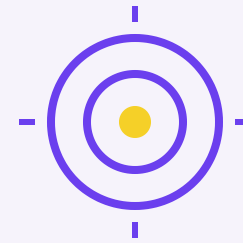
Three things a **good problem statement** does



O1

User-centred

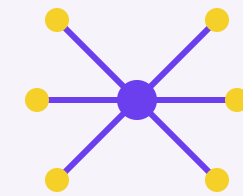
Describes a real person's problem — not a business goal, a feature request, or a technical constraint.



O2

Specific, not vague

"Users struggle to track booking status" beats "users find the product confusing." Precision makes it testable.



O3

Open to multiple solutions

Doesn't hint at the answer. Opens possibility instead of closing it down.

— THE FORMULA

The problem statement formula



FILLED
IN

First-time online shoppers need a way to know their order was confirmed immediately after payment because the current delay and lack of feedback causes them to abandon — and sometimes re-order — thinking the transaction failed .

Weak statement **vs** strong statement

WEAK

- ✗ "We need to redesign the checkout flow." — solution, not a problem.
- ✗ "Users don't trust the app." — too vague to act on.
- ✗ "The app needs better notifications." — solution, not user-centred.

STRONG

- ✓ "First-time buyers need a way to confirm their order was placed because the lack of feedback after payment causes them to re-submit, creating duplicate orders."
- ✓ "New users need a way to verify their account is set up correctly because there is no onboarding confirmation — leading them to contact support before their first action."
- ✓ "Frequent users need a way to know when a status change happens without opening the app because they miss time-sensitive updates — causing delays and frustration."

ACTIVITY 04 • 15 MIN

15 Draft the problem statement for your project.

Use the formula. Ground it in what you actually heard.

Before Session 4

TASK 01 · AFFINITY MAPPING

Run affinity mapping on all your interview notes

- Use FigJam, Miro, or physical sticky notes.
- Look for super-themes and outliers.
- Bring the named clusters to Session 4.

TASK 02 · INSIGHT STATEMENTS

Write 3 insight statements from your research

- Use the Observation + Implication formula for each.
- Push the implication until it's product-specific.
- Don't stop at the obvious — the third pass is where the real insight lives.

TASK 03 · SHARE IT

Share your problem statement with one stakeholder

- Pick a PM, engineer, or team lead.
- Note how they respond — confusion is data.
- Update the statement if they were unclear about who or why.

AFTER TODAY, YOU SHOULD HAVE ONE THING

*A problem
worth solving.*

— Winnie Nguyen